Rainy Yuzhen Dong, Ph.D.

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Developmental psychologist with expertise in language and reading development across early and middle childhood. Experienced in corpus-based methods, experimental methods, and large-scale data modelling in R. with a keen interest in translating research into practice through educational tools and collaboration with educators and other stakeholders.

CURRENT POSITION

Postdoctoral Fellow (Advisor: Elika Bergelson)
Lab for Developmental Studies, Department of Psychology, Harvard University, US — Jan 2025 - Current

EDUCATION

DPhil Experimental Psychology (Advisors: Kate Nation & Robert Hepach)
Department of Experimental Psychology, University of Oxford, UK — Oct 2021 - Jan 2025
Thesis: Emotion Language in Context: Investigating Emotion Words in Children's Written Language and Word Learning

BSc Psychology
University College London, UK — Sep 2018 - Jun 2021

SELECTED RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

Postdoctoral Fellow, Bergelson Lab, Harvard University — Jan 2025 - Current

- Analyzed longitudinal corpora of children's early language environment (6-54 mo.) using complex mixed-effect modeling
- Validated a parental word exposure survey against item-level corpus frequency and standardized CDI measures
- Conducted behavioral experiments using looking-while-listening and headturn preference to investigate early word comprehension among infants (10-24 mo.)

Doctoral Researcher, ReadOxford Lab, University of Oxford — Oct 2021 - Jan 2025

- Analyzed six large-scale language corpora using NLP tools (sentiment analysis, topic modelling) for emotion words and emotional content in children's reading and writing (5-16 y/o)
- Conducted item-level corpus analyses to evaluate lexical frequency and contextual valence of emotion words across ages
- Developed and assessed the construct validity of an author recognition test as a proxy for children's reading experience
- Designed behavioral experiments to assess how reading valenced narrative context supports children's novel word learning
- Organized international research workshop on cross-linguistic corpus analysis methods in children's reading development

Research Assistant, Human Centered Computing, King's College London — Jun 2020 - Sep 2021

- Co-designed and deployed the smart toy Purrble in primary school settings to support children's emotion regulation
- Assessed intervention effectiveness through focus group discussions and co-design workshops with educators
- Conducted qualitative analysis of parenting forums to promote digital child mental health interventions

RESEARCH & ANALYTICAL SKILLS

Statistical & Psychometric Methods -- R

- Mixed-effects modeling (*lme4*), model comparison, structural equation modeling, reliability analysis (*psych*)
- Corpus-based lexical analysis, sentiment analysis, topic modelling

Reproducible Research -- RMarkdown, Git, GitHub

SELECTED PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Literacy Specialist, Crescendo Literacy Program, Dr Lucy Brown-Wright Ltd. Jan 2020 - Sep 2024

- Delivered individualized reading intervention for children (7-13 y/o) with language and literacy difficulties
- Applied behaviorist techniques (e.g., operant conditioning with descriptive praise) to reinforce positive reading habits
- Collaborated with clinical psychologist and parents to tailor strategies and monitor developmental progress
- Designed and led training and onboarding sessions for over 20 incoming tutors, standardizing instructional practices

Teaching Fellow & Lab Demonstrator, University of Oxford Oct 2022 - Mar 2024

- Designed and delivered small-group tutorials on courses including *Developmental Science* and *Cognition*
- Demonstrated in Practical Lab sessions for 120+ college students in *Introduction to Statistics* and *Developmental Science*
- Coordinated with course leader and other tutors to incorporate feedback and improve teaching effectiveness

Founder, MindMe Psychology Promoting Group Feb 2019 - Jun 2021

- Founded an online initiative to make psychological science accessible, reaching 3,000+ readers

Team Leader, Behavioral Science Hackathon 2022, UCL Centre for Behavior Change Apr 2022

- Directed a cross-disciplinary team to develop a behavioral intervention targeting environmental behavior change

Bilingual Tutor, Cambridge Youth Summer Camp, China Jul 2019 – Aug 2019

- Supported English language learning and confidence through creative activities for multi-age youth groups (8-18 y/o)

PUBLICATIONS & SCIENCE COMMUNICATION

Paper

- **Dong, Y.**, Moore, C., Ramadurai, J., & Bergelson, E. (accepted). Measuring Early Word Exposure in Infants: A Brief Parent-Report Survey Captures Individual Language Input and Predicts Vocabulary Outcomes. *Developmental Psychology*
- **Dong, Y.**, Mak, M. H., Hepach, R., & Nation, K. (2026). Emotional Words, Emotional Contexts: Investigating Emotional Valence in Children's Writing and Word Learning. *Infant and Child Development, 35*(1), e70083
- **Dong, Y.**, Nation, K. (2025). Charting the frequency and diversity of emotion words in children's language: written language matters. *First Language*, *45*(4), 457-475.
- **Dong, Y.**, Mak, M. H., Hepach, R., & Nation, K. (2024). Learning New Words via Reading: The Influence of Emotional Narrative Context on Learning Novel Adjectives. *Quarterly Journal of Experimental Psychology, 78*(10), 2167-2180.
- **Dong, Y.,** Hsiao, Y., Dawson, N., Banerji, N., Nation, K. (2024). The Emotional Content of Children's Writing: A Data-Driven Approach. *Cognitive Science, 48*(3), e13423.
- Ibrahim, S., Ang, J. R. X., Petsolari, M., Michelson, R., **Dong, Y.**, Theofanopoulou, N., ... & Slovák, P. (2024). Understanding Online Parental Help-Seeking and Help-Giving in Early Childhood: The Design Challenges of Supporting Complex Parenting Questions. *Proceedings of the ACM on Human-Computer Interaction*, *8*(CSCW1), 1-36.

Selected Conference Presentations

- Boston University Conference on Language Development Annual Meeting — Nov 2025
- Cognitive Science Society Annual Meeting — Jul 2025, 2024, 2023
- Society for Affective Science Annual Meeting — Mar 2025
- Society for Scientific Study of Reading Annual Conference — Jul 2024, 2023
- Experimental Psychology Society Meeting — Jan 2024, Sep 2023

Academic Service

- Ad-hoc reviewer for: Behavioral Research Methods, Journal of Child Language, Cognitive Science Society Conference